

The River Dragon's Long Sleep

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.*

Before you begin

All through the long, dry summer the rains had not come. The Silver River, which fed every terraced field in the valley, sank lower week by week, until the young rice stood pale and thirsty and the elders watched the cloudless sky with worried faces.

For high on the mountain, in a deep bend of the river, slept the Gentle River Dragon, whose slow stirring had brought the rains since before anyone could remember. This year he had slept far too long, and no one knew how to wake him.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper called the two of you to her side. "You have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more up the mountain than any strength. Will you climb over the pass and wake him, gently, before the harvest fails?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a little bronze bell with a clear, soft ring, a ball of bright red thread, and a sweet rice cake wrapped in a leaf. "Remember," she said, "up there we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Kindness?*

Stop 1 The Guardian Gate

The path climbed steeply through the cedars until it reached the Red Torii Gate, tall and vermilion against the green of the mountain. On either side crouched a great stone lion-dog, so still you might have walked straight past them. Then, as you drew near, the stone seemed to soften: they blinked, they stretched, and they turned their carved heads to look at you.

"None may pass," the Guardian Lion-Dogs rumbled together, "until you answer our riddle." Their voices were deep as a temple drum, and for a moment your heart beat quick. But there was no cruelty in their eyes, only a fair and patient sort of watchfulness. They would have liked a good idea, and they would not have minded a brave, thoughtful guess.

★ *Will you listen closely and puzzle it out together? Kon the Fox is somewhere near the bamboo, and he loves to whisper a hint. What do you try?*

When your answer came, the Guardian Lion-Dogs nodded slowly and settled back onto their pedestals. "Well thought," they said, and a low, pleased rumble followed you as the great gate swung open and let you through.

Stop 2 The Moonlit Bridge

Beyond the gate the daylight faded, and a round silver moon rose over the river. There the path met an old arched bridge of dark wood, beautiful and a little frightening, for it swayed and groaned whenever the wind pushed at it. The water ran fast and black far below.

You understood, almost at once, what the bridge asked of you. It held firm only for those who crossed it slowly and calmly, together: no rushing, no fear-driven scramble, just one steady step after another, with a brave and quiet heart.

★ *How will you cross? Will you go gently, side by side, breathing slow? You might tie the red thread between you so that you stay together all the way. What is your plan?*

By crossing slowly and calmly, hand in hand, you kept the bridge steady beneath your feet. It carried you the whole long arc above the water, and set you down at last on the far bank, safe in the drifting mist.

Stop 3 The Sleeping Dragon

And there, at last, lay the great River Dragon. He was curled along a deep, misty bend of the river, his long body vast as a green hill, his breath rising and falling slow as the tide. He had slept so very long that mist had gathered on his scales and reeds had grown between his claws. He looked, for a moment, like the end of the adventure.

But this was never a fight, and could never be one. You could no more battle such a creature than battle the mountain itself, and you would not have wished to. He was not fierce. He was gentle, and, you slowly understood, he was lonely, for no one had climbed all this way to sit with him in a very long time.

★ *This calls for a calm and careful kindness. You carry a little bell that rings soft and clear, the kind of sound that wakes a friend without a fright. You could ring it gently and sing him a quiet song. What do you do?*

When you rang the little bell and sang, soft and low, the great dragon's sleepy eyes drifted open, deep and dark and kind. "Someone came," he murmured, as though he could scarcely believe it. "Someone came to wake me kindly, and not with shouting." And he smiled, slow as sunrise.

The Rains Return

The River Dragon uncurled and rose, grand and unhurried, into the moonlit sky. He wound above the valley like a long blue ribbon, and everywhere his shadow passed, a soft, warm rain began to fall, the first rain of the whole long summer.

The Silver River swelled and brimmed and shone. Far below, the thirsty rice fields drank deep and turned, almost as you watched, a glad and living green. And the dragon was lonely no longer, for now he had two friends who would climb the mountain to see him again.

As the clouds thinned, Amaterasu the Sun-Kami broke through with a warm gold light and smiled down upon you. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your imagination, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Blossom Mountains.

The River Dragon's Long Sleep: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, with a long climb, a swaying bridge by moonlight, and a great sleeping dragon, but imagination and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Lantern Village.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a small bell or anything that makes a soft sound, a ball of string for the red thread, and a small cake or token for the rice cake. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these mountains, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line

that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Kon the Fox slips from the bamboo and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your calm again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts down the mountain, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Guardian Lion-Dogs nod kindly from afar. All is well.
5	A lucky cherry petal lands in your hand: keep one roll to use again later.
6	The soft ring of a temple bell sounds far off, and everyone feels calm and brave.

How it ends

The Gentle River Dragon at the misty river is the great "obstacle", but he is no villain at all. He is not angry, and he is not wicked; he is simply a kind old creature who has slept far too long and grown a little lonely. The tale is won not by force or by shouting, which would only frighten him, but by waking him gently and kindly, with the soft little bell and a calm, friendly song. Let that gentleness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The River Dragon's Long Sleep: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Guardian Gate (Normal)

The challenge. The two stone Guardian Lion-Dogs at the Red Torii Gate will not open the way until the players answer their riddle. They look fierce, but they are fair and patient, and they enjoy a good thinking face.

The riddle. Read it aloud: "I fall without ever being dropped. I drum on every roof, yet I have no hands. The thirsty fields all call my name. What am I?" The answer is **the rain** (the very thing the valley is waiting for).

Intended solution. This is a thinking challenge of Imagination and a little patience. Let the children talk it through together. The Guardian Lion-Dogs accept the right answer, and because they are fair and kind, they also accept a brave, thoughtful guess.

Fallback. If they are stuck, the lion-dogs offer a clue ("The whole valley is waiting for me, and the dragon's waking brings me"), or Kon the Fox whispers the answer from the bamboo nearby. A guess made bravely still opens the gate.

Stop 2: The Moonlit Bridge (Normal)

The challenge. The arched wooden bridge over the river sways and creaks. It holds firm only for those who cross slowly and calmly, together. The players must get safely across.

Intended solution. This is a Spatial and Courage moment. The thoughtful move is to cross **gently and together**: slow, steady steps, side by side, breathing calm rather than rushing in a fright. Tying the **red thread** between them so they stay linked, or counting out a slow, even rhythm as they walk, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are uneasy, let them take a deep breath and try again with no penalty, or have Kon the Fox call out a calming rhythm to walk to. Crossing with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Sleeping Dragon (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. The great River Dragon lies curled in the misty river, vast and mighty. The players may feel this is a battle, or that they must shout him awake. It is neither.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Courage moment. The dragon is gentle and a little lonely, and a loud noise would only startle him. The kind, brave move is to wake him **softly**: ring the **little bell**, whose clear, gentle sound wakes a friend without a fright, and sing him a quiet, calm song. Speaking to him gently, or offering the **rice cake** when he wakes, deepens the friendship. When the children are gentle, the dragon opens his sleepy eyes and is glad someone came.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to "win" by force, have the dragon stir and murmur in his sleep, "Please, not so loud," so the gentle path is clear. The moment the players make any soft, kind sound at all, the bell or a hummed tune, the great dragon wakes warmly and is glad of their company.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the dragon wakes and rises, the soft rains return, the Silver River brims, the thirsty rice fields drink and turn green, and **Amaterasu the Sun-Kami** smiles down through the clouds. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins

here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 3.5, updated 2026-06-05, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.